

Food Reservoir for Escherichia coli Causing Urinary Tract Infections

Closely related strains of *Escherichia coli* have been shown to cause extraintestinal infections in unrelated persons. This study tests whether a food reservoir may exist for these *E. coli*. Isolates from 3 sources over the same time period (2005–2007) and geographic area were compared. The sources comprised prospectively collected *E. coli* isolates from women with urinary tract infection (UTI) (n = 353); retail meat (n = 417); and restaurant/ready-to-eat foods (n = 74). *E. coli* were evaluated for antimicrobial drug susceptibility and O:H serotype and compared by using 4 different genotyping methods. We identified 17 clonal groups that contained *E. coli* isolates (n = 72) from >1 source. *E. coli* from retail chicken (O25:H4-ST131 and O114:H4-ST117) and honeydew melon (O2:H7-ST95) were indistinguishable from or closely related to *E. coli* from human UTIs. This study provides strong support for the role of food reservoirs or foodborne transmission in the dissemination of *E. coli* causing common community-acquired UTIs.